The 4th Degree – Secret Master



The apron is white, edged with black, and has black ties. These two colors symbolize the grief suffered by the Masons upon hearing of the Master Hiram's death and the loss of the word. As well, they are illustrative of the dualist nature of the universe, containing light and darkness, good and evil, truth and error. The flap is of sky blue with an open eye embroidered upon it in gold, denoting the sun as the great archetype of light, the Ineffable Deity. In its center is a "Z" embroidered in gold and around it are two crossed wreaths of laurel and olive.

The jewel is a small ivory key with a black "Z" upon the wards. It is worn suspended from a broad yellow ribbon edged in deep blue or black. The gold symbolizes light emerging from darkness. The initials *C. a. M.* denote *Clavis ad Mysterium*, the "key to the mystery." The jewel of the Master is a small equilateral triangle of gold emblazoned with the Greek letters: I–A–Ω (*iota, alpha, omega*) at the apexes. Pike tells us, "The Name of Deity, in many Nations,

consisted of three letters: among the Greeks, I–A–Ω...” (p. 632). On its reverse are the Samaritan characters 𐤉–𐤄–𐤅 (*yud, he,* and *vau*); these three letters, with *he* duplicated are used to form the Ineffable Name of Deity, called the Tetragrammaton, usually pronounced as *yahweh*. Pike, though he uses the Hebrew forms, also explains their significance as representing three of the ten *Sephiroth,* or emanations from Deity, of the Kabbalah: *gedulah, gevurah,* and *tipharet;* that is, Mercy, Justice and Beauty (p. 798).

The significance of the letter “Z” is esoteric and thus is not proper to be discussed here. It is the initial of the password of this degree. In the Hebrew numerology of the Kabbalah its equivalent letter had the value of 7, a number familiar to all Masons.

DUTIES

Practice silence, obedience, fidelity.

LESSONS

The teachings of Masonry are not to be taken lightly.

Learning far outlasts physical monuments.

Duties are not to be performed expecting reward but expecting personal satisfaction.

FOR REFLECTION

May one command who does not know how to obey?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

The color black with silver tears, Adoniram, key of ivory, blazing star, wreath of laurel and olive leaves, the great Masonic camp, the three pillars, the nine Masonic virtues.

The concept of duty in Scottish Rite Masonry demands attention, reflection and understanding. Since the 4th Degree is the first degree of the Lodge of Perfection, it lays the foundation for the succeeding degrees and provides instruction on specific virtues. Pike says:

DUTY IS THE ONE GREAT LAW OF MASONRY

And further, in the 4th Degree ominous voices from three directions characterize duty as

Inflexible as Fate and Exacting as Necessity,
Rising with us in the morning and
Watching at our pillows at night.
Duty is with us always, imperative as Destiny.

In every degree, we are confronted with our duty directly or reminded of it via the opening and closing ritual or the characterization of such heroic figures as the Master Architect Hiram, King Solomon, Adoniram or Jacques De Molay. Duty forms the core of philosophical and religious instructions derived from the ancients of the past: Plato, Socrates, Pythagoras, Zoroaster, Jesus, Confucius. We style ourselves Princes, Knights, Chiefs and Masters, not in the earthly sense of titles by which one man may be seen as better in some way than another; rather in assuming such titles we take on the duties inherent in them to become the examples of proper conduct all leaders are, or should be. Throughout *Morals and Dogma* duty is discussed in a multitude of arenas—the Lodge, the Masonic fraternity, the family, the community, the country and the world:

Out of all the relations of life grow duties,
as naturally grow and as undeniably,
as the leaves grow upon the trees.

CEREMONY

The Lodge of Secret Masters represents the gathering of the Princes of Israel upon Hiram's death. The area behind the railing with a gate is called the Holy of Holies where, as we learned in the allegory of the 3rd Degree in the Symbolic Lodge, our Master Hiram was wont to offer up his devotions and pray for wisdom; it symbolizes the most secret mysteries of Masonry which are being sought by the candidate. To remind us of the tragedy of Hiram's death, the hangings (or curtains) and the altar cover are black and strewn with silver tears. They should also remind us of the loss of the True Word which the candidate

seeks. Since work has been suspended on the Temple, no working tools are seen. The principal characters are King Solomon, chosen to build the Temple (1 Kings 5:6), and Adoniram, who was “over the tribute” or levy; that is, he was the superintendent of the conscripted laborers (1 Kings 4:6).

The ceremony strikes a familiar setting but there is no plot because the purpose of this degree is not so much to illustrate virtues as it is to lay the foundation for the entire system of the Scottish Rite degrees. Duty and its importance in Scottish Rite Masonry are stressed in the ceremony. The duties of a Scottish Rite Mason are not to be performed in the hope or expectation of earthly rewards or honors but in the simple expectation of personal satisfaction. These duties form the path which leads to the object of the Masonic quest, the True Word. The wreaths of laurel and olive symbolize the hopeful expectation of success in that search. The square is a reminder that the candidate has begun a great journey; it is, however, not a simple journey. He has passed from the square to the compasses; the square representing earthly things and the compasses representing spiritual things. (p. 11)

The lights of the lodge represent the first cube, 2 × 2 × 2. To the ancients it represented perfection, friendship, prudence, council, and justice (pp. 635–636). Through the concepts of light and darkness, truth and error, we see the foreshadowing of the dualist doctrine which forms an important part of Scottish Rite teachings. Dualism teaches by way of analogy the idea of opposites in both the universe and human experience. This doctrine is more fully explained at the end of the lecture in *Morals and Dogma* for the Knight of the East and West (pp. 272–275).

The Scottish Rite shares in common many of the symbols of the York Rite Symbolic Lodge. The interpretation of these symbols in the Scottish Rite closely adheres to the ancient meanings. This degree explains some of this symbolism: the columns Wisdom, Strength and Beauty are now called Wisdom, Power and Harmony, anticipating a more complete explanation of the contributions of the school of Judaic mysticism called the Kabbalah. The all–seeing eye now also represents the sun as the source of light without intending any offense to its more

traditional interpretation; the blazing star symbolizes the search for truth; and the letter “G” is now a Samaritan letter, still representative of the true God.

The principles taught in this degree—silence, obedience and fidelity—are conveyed directly through the obligation taken by the candidate and the closing. These are also illustrated symbolically. The placement of the candidate’s right hand upon his lips is a symbol of silence or secrecy. This position is derived from statues of the Greek child—deity Harpocrates, who was adopted from the Egyptian deity Horus, also represented on the apron of the 21st Degree. The son of Osiris and Isis, Horus was the victor in the battle against Set (or Typhon as he was called by the Greeks and Pike) who was the principal agent of evil in the Egyptian pantheon. Thus, silence is one of the virtues through which good triumphs over evil. The jewel of this degree, a key of ivory, is also an emblem of secrecy and serves as a reminder that we are the custodians of the True Word; it should be locked up in our hearts. The candidate is instructed:

Prepare yourself to command, by learning to obey.

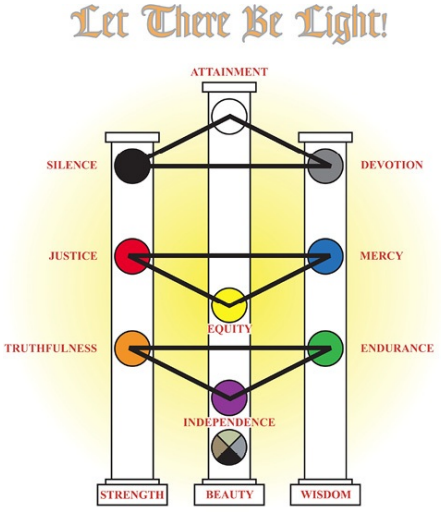
We find the personification of fidelity in the character of Adoniram who is to be “faithful unto death.” This is a rather obscure reference to the Biblical account (1 Kings 12:18) which tells of Adoniram’s death by stoning during his attempt to enforce tax collection under Rehoboam, successor to Solomon. The length of his service (over 50 years) suggests the possibility of two Adonirams.

The placing of the hand over the heart in the ritual is a symbol of fidelity. This may remind you of the standard mode of pledging allegiance to the flag. Both hint at the ancient representation of fidelity by a hand holding a heart.

The candidate’s quest is to learn how he may best prepare himself to symbolically use the ivory key he was given to open the gate and attain greater “Light and Knowledge,” which is Truth. He is informed that Freemasonry neither encroaches upon the just privileges of religion, nor does it claim to provide salvation of the soul or entrance into Heaven. It affirms that God exists, that there is benefit in prayer, and that man owes it to himself to return to that Sanctuary which best increases his faith in our Creator. Freemasonry encourages

men to turn to their Creator and worship according to the dictates of their own consciences. The candidate is informed that, in the fold of his religion, he should pray, study the Book of the Sacred Law, and turn from his errors. To help him discern Truth is encouraged to study reason and the science of logic. Its rules and syllogisms, when understood, will help separate Truth from falsehood. When we can do this, we will be able to form reasonable opinions without having to rely on the opinions of others.

The discovery of Truth is the principal quest of religion and philosophy. As an example of this, the candidate is told about the Kabbalah. This mystical branch of Judaism is only introduced as a teaching aid, and not as a personal or religious doctrine. Like other systems of philosophy it explores with vivid detail the great questions on the nature of God, the origin of the material world, and the relationship of God to man. This system is introduced as a tradition built upon symbolism, and worthy of consideration. In connection with this, the candidate is taught that Wisdom, Strength and Beauty, the three principle supports of a Lodge, correspond to the three pillars of the "Tree of Life," one of the principle symbols of symbolic Kabbalah. In this Degree nine emanations, or out–flowings of the Deity, each typify a Masonic virtue: *Independence, Truthfulness, Endurance, Equity, Justice, Mercy, Silence, Devotion* and *Attainment.*



LECTURE

In *Morals and Dogma*, Pike expands upon the foundation laid in the ceremony. Truth must be sought for in study, reflection and discrimination. He says that the "streams of learning that now flow full and broad must be followed to their heads in the springs that well up in the remote past, and you will there find the origin and meaning of Masonry" (p. 107). Learning is the ultimate accomplishment of human purpose and far outlasts the physical monuments erected by the hand of man. Thus the teachings of Masonry are not to be acquired lightly or to be taken so after they are learned.

Silence is important because it prevents demands upon us which we are only obligated to perform for the benefit of a truly needful brother, which demands can be exacted far in excess of simple human charity.

Obedience is not blindness to tyranny but the proper submission of the individual will to the necessary demands of living in a society.

Fidelity was one of the highest of virtues even among the ancients. We must strive always to keep faith with God and our fellows otherwise our obligations are meaningless and our words snares for the simple.

Silence:

Secrecy is indispensable in a Mason of whatever Degree. … how profound a folly it would be to betray our secrets to those who, bound to us by no tie of common obligation, might, by obtaining them, call on us in their extremity, when the urgency of the occasion should allow us no time for inquiry, and the peremptory mandate of our obligation compel us to do a brother's duty to a base impostor (p. 109).

Obedience:

… obedience to the Law does not mean submission to tyranny… (p. 110).

There is one true and original law, conformable to reason and to nature, diffused over all, invariable, eternal, which calls to the fulfillment of duty, and to abstinence from injustice, and calls with that irresistible voice which is felt in all

its authority wherever it is heard. This law cannot be abrogated or diminished, or its sanctions affected, by any law of man (p. 110).

All the general measures of justice, are the laws of God, and therefore they constitute the general rules of government for the conscience… (p. 111).

Fidelity:

When thou vowest a vow unto God, defer not to pay it (p. 111).

Weigh well what it is you promise; but once the promise and pledge are given remember that he who is false to his obligation will be false to his family, his friends, his country, and his God (pp. 111-12).

Faith plighted is ever to be kept, was a maxim and an axiom even among pagans (p. 112).

The word of a Mason, like the word of a knight in the times of chivalry, once given must be sacred… (p. 112).

Be faithful to your friends…. Be faithful to your country…. Be faithful to Masonry…. Thus will you be faithful to yourself… (pp. 112-13).